

Past modals of deduction

GRAMMAR

LEVEL
Intermediate

NUMBER
EN_BE_3823G

LANGUAGE
English

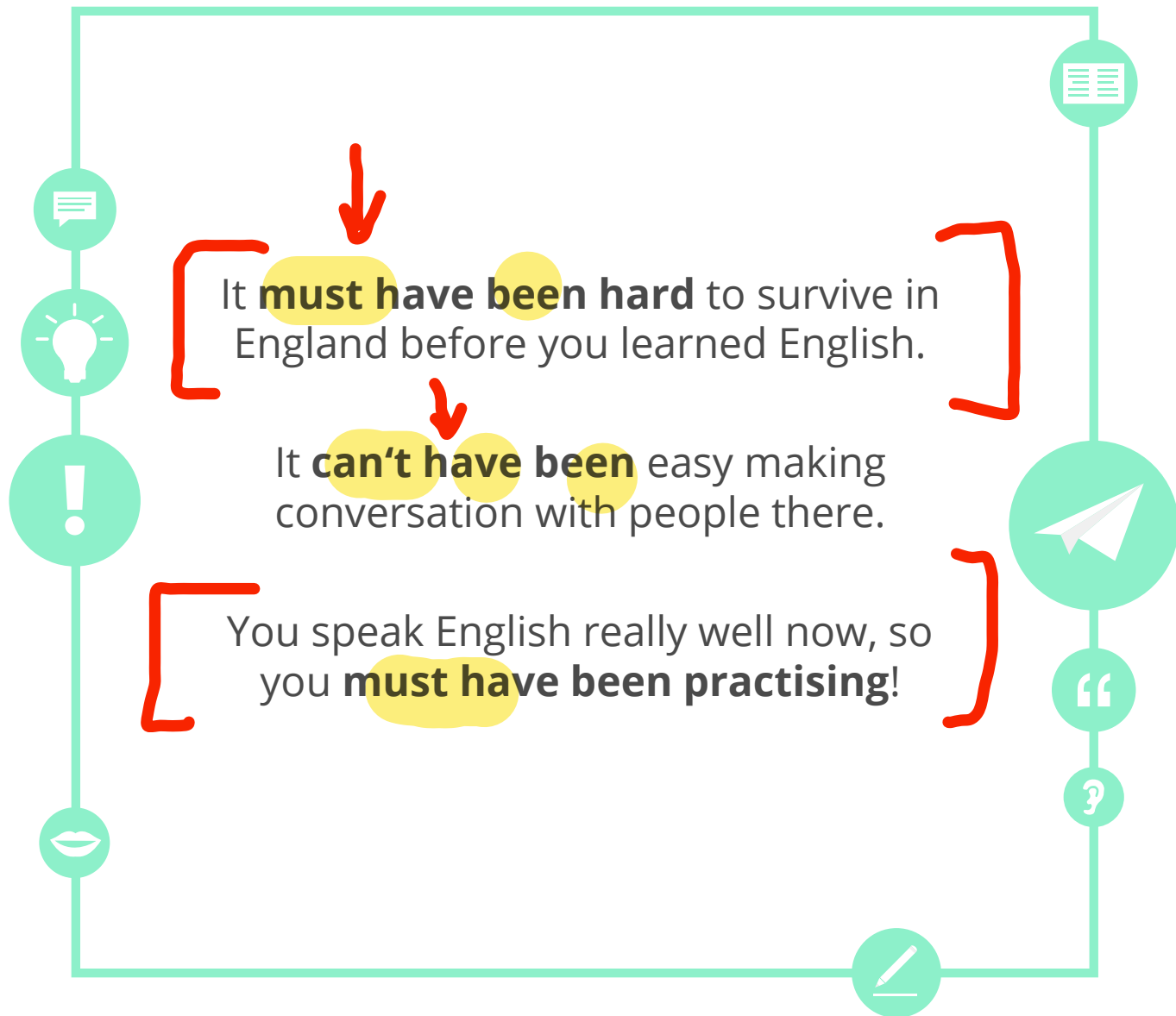




Goals

- Can identify past modals of deduction and explain their use.
- Can accurately use a range of modals of deduction to speculate about actions in the past.







Preview and warm-up

- In this lesson, we will practise using **past modals of deduction** to discuss events that we **believe** to have happened in the **past**.



Tom bought a very expensive car yesterday, so he **must have won** the lottery!

“

Must have/mustn't have

- **Must** is used when we are **certain** that something happened in the **past**.
- We use this structure:
 - **must + have + past participle.**



They **must have closed** the road because of the snow.

Patricia **mustn't have checked** his emails properly, otherwise he would have seen the urgent request.





Might, may and could have

- We use ***might***, ***may***, and ***could*** when we think it is **possible** that something **happened in the past**, but we are **not certain**.
- We use this structure:
 - ***Might/may/could* + have + past participle.**



Mark **might have eaten** lunch already.
I'm not sure, so let's ask him.

Anthony **could have spoken** to the client already. Please check before you call them.



“

Can't, couldn't have



- Take care with *can't* or *couldn't have*!
- Their meaning is different from *may not* and *might not*.
- What is the difference between the two sentences below?



James **can't / couldn't have known** it was my birthday. I didn't tell anyone at the office.

→ James **might not have known** it was my birthday. I only told a few people.





Match the sentences

What do each of these sentences mean?

90%
→ 1. They can't have read my email.

90%
- 2. They must have read my email.

100%
= 3. They have read my email.

= 4. They might/may have read my email. 70%

a. I know for certain that they have read my email.

b. I believe it's possible that they have read my email.

c. I believe they haven't read my email.

d. I believe they have read my email.



Complete the sentences using *must have* or *can't have*



1. I haven't seen Albert working at the bar in ages. (he / change jobs)

Example: He must have changed jobs.



2. Barbara is still taking the bus. (she / pass / her driving test)



3. I love your new dress! (it / expensive)



4. Antonio hasn't arrived yet. (his flight / delayed)

his flight must have been delayed





Using past modals of deduction

There are two short dialogues below. Use **might have** + past participle or **couldn't have** + past participle to complete the sentences.



Was the client we met last week American?

I'm not sure. He **might have** Canadian.



Which printer did Frances use to print the agenda yesterday?

She the new printer, because that was only installed this morning.





Using past modals of deduction

Here are two more dialogues. This time, use *might not have* + past participle or *could have* + past participle to complete the sentences.



Why do you think Imran wasn't at the conference this year?

might not have heard/know

I don't know. He _____ about it.



Do you think Jessie is coming?



Maybe not. She could have forgotten

may/might





What could have happened to the missing mug?

Rosie's mug is missing at the office. Roman and Amelia are investigating its disappearance. Read the dialogue and fill the gaps with the correct use of modal verbs.

Amelia: Rosie thinks she might have left it in the staff kitchen but she may not have brought it to work today at all.

Roman: Someone must have used it by mistake. What does it look like?

Amelia: It is a lovely deep red with cool white snowflakes on it. Whoever took it must have noticed them. It is a very recognisable and desirable mug.

Roman: Well Phillipe says it can't have been him who took it, as he hasn't had a hot drink today.

Amelia: Rosie says she took it out of the cupboard and then her phone rang, so she went to her desk. It might have been taken then. must have been

Roman: I don't think we should waste time with this...





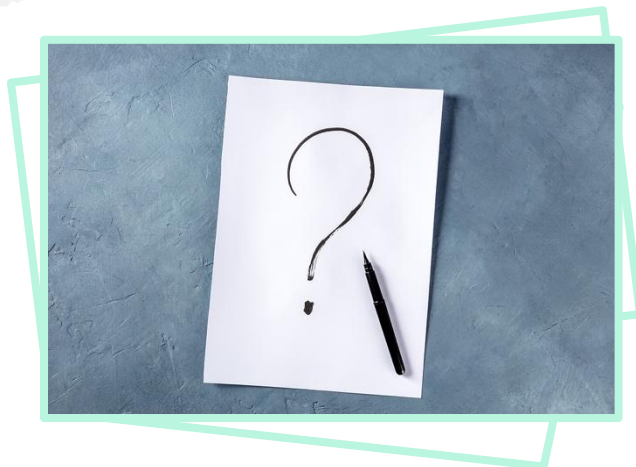
Writing with modals

Rosie's mug is still missing. Roman and Amelia have some evidence, but they have not found the mug so they must deduce what happened.

What do you think might have happened to the mug?

Amelia really likes
the mug...

Roman wants to
stop the
investigation...



“

Must/mustn't have been ...ing

- When we are **almost certain** that an **action was happening over a period of time** in the **past**, we use the structure:
 - **must + have + been + -ing form of the verb**
- The action **started in the past** and may **still be continuing to take place now**.



I'm so sorry I'm late! You **must have been waiting for ages!**

The team **mustn't have been working** efficiently, which explains the project delay.





Might, may and could have been ...ing

- When it's **possible** that an action was **happening over a period of time in the past**, we use the structure:
 - ***Might/may/could + have + been + -ing form of the verb***



He **might have been cooking** when I got home. I think I saw a light on in the kitchen.

I **could have been paying** too much rent since last year. I need to call my landlord and check.

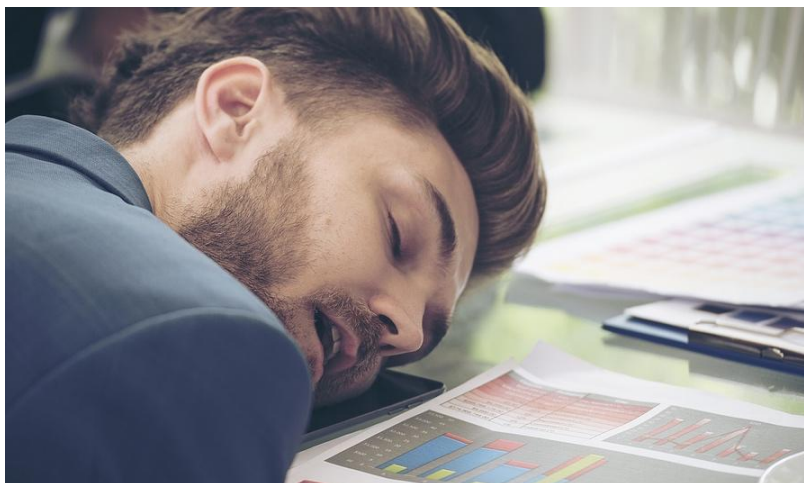




Can't have been ...ing



- We use **can't/couldn't + have + been + -ing form** when we believe it is not possible for something to have been happening in the past.



Ian **can't have been listening** during the meeting. He was falling asleep at the table.



Must have been and can't have been in deductions

Can you explain how the two sentences below differ in meaning?



I **must have been**
driving faster than
30mph. +

I **can't have been**
driving faster than
30mph. -



Complete the sentences

1. Edward is soaking wet! (he / walk / rain)

Example: He **must have been walking in the rain.**



2. How did she find out? (listen / someone)

3. Did I wake you? (I / snore/ **that** loudly)

_____ I can't have been snoring that loudly

4. I didn't see the film. (Joanna / watch before she went to bed)





Match the sentences to the pictures and use continuous forms to complete them

1. She _____ where she was going. (**can't / look**)

2. He didn't hear the doorbell. He having _____. (**must / shower**)

3. Clive didn't come. He _____ his son from school. (**might / collect**)

4. They broke up. Things H _____ well. (**can't / go**)

5. You _____. You were watching TV! (**couldn't / study**)

6. Grace is sweaty. She A _____. (**must / run**)

7. C _____

8. D _____

A



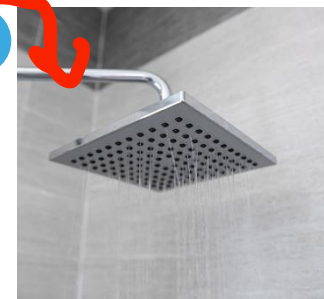
C



E



G



D



F



H



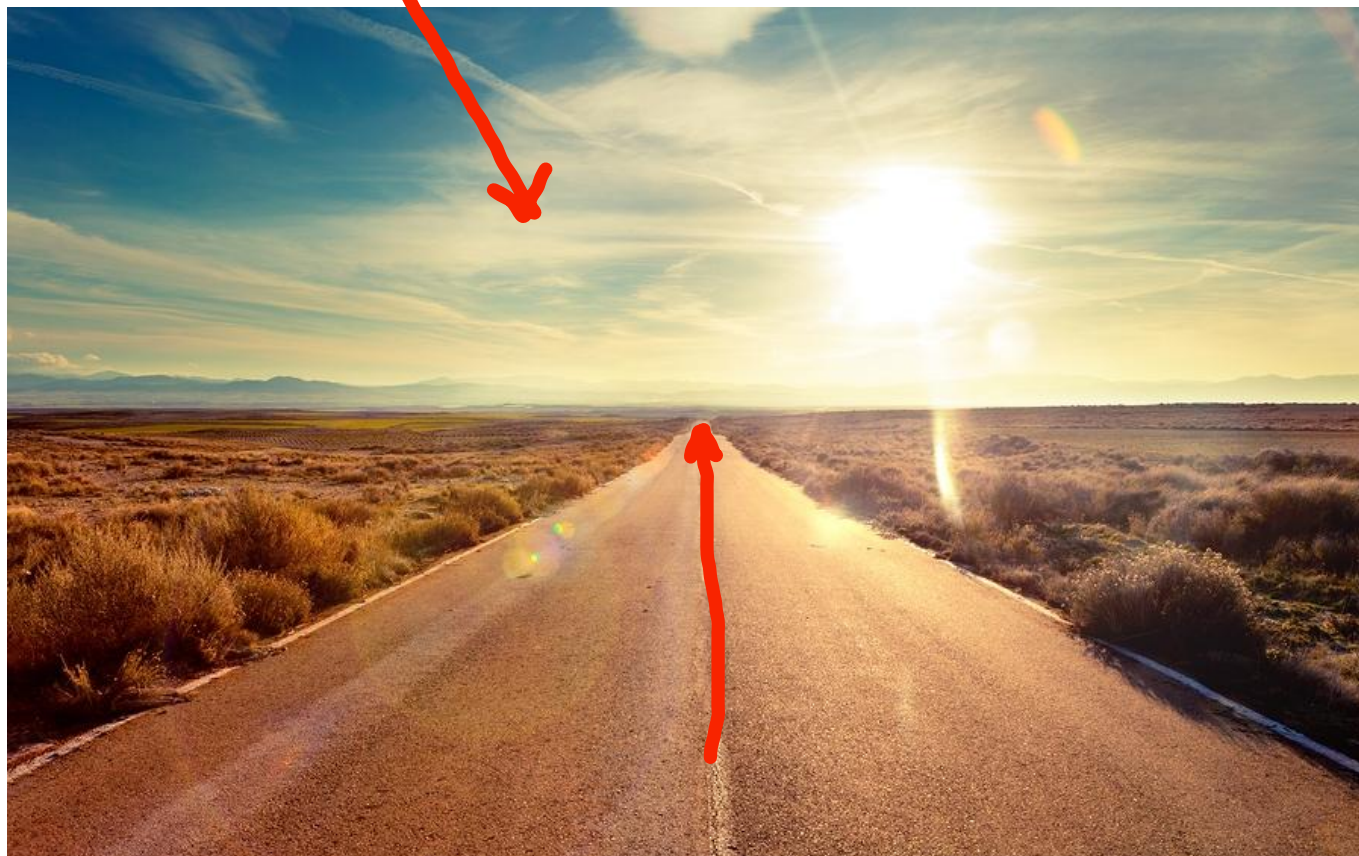
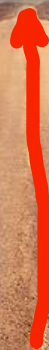
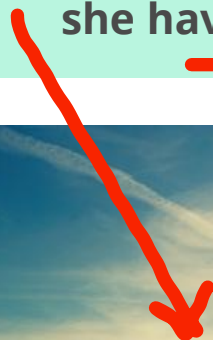
Think of your own sentences for numbers 7 and 8!



Look at the following photo



Where could the photographer have taken this photo? What could he or she have been doing there?





Reflect on the goals

Go back to the second slide of the lesson and check if you have achieved all the goals of the lesson.

yes

no





Reflect on this lesson

Think about everything you have seen in this lesson.
What were the most difficult activities or words? The easiest?



If you have time, go over
the most difficult slides again



Answer key 1/2

Exercise p. 8
1. c 2. d 3. a 4. b

Exercise p. 9
2. She **can't have passed** her driving test.
3. It **must have been expensive**.
4. His flight **must have been delayed**.

Exercise p. 10
He **might/could/may have been** Canadian.
She **couldn't have used** the new printer.

Exercise p. 11
He **might not have known** about it.
She **could have forgotten**.



Answer key 2/2

Exercise p. 12

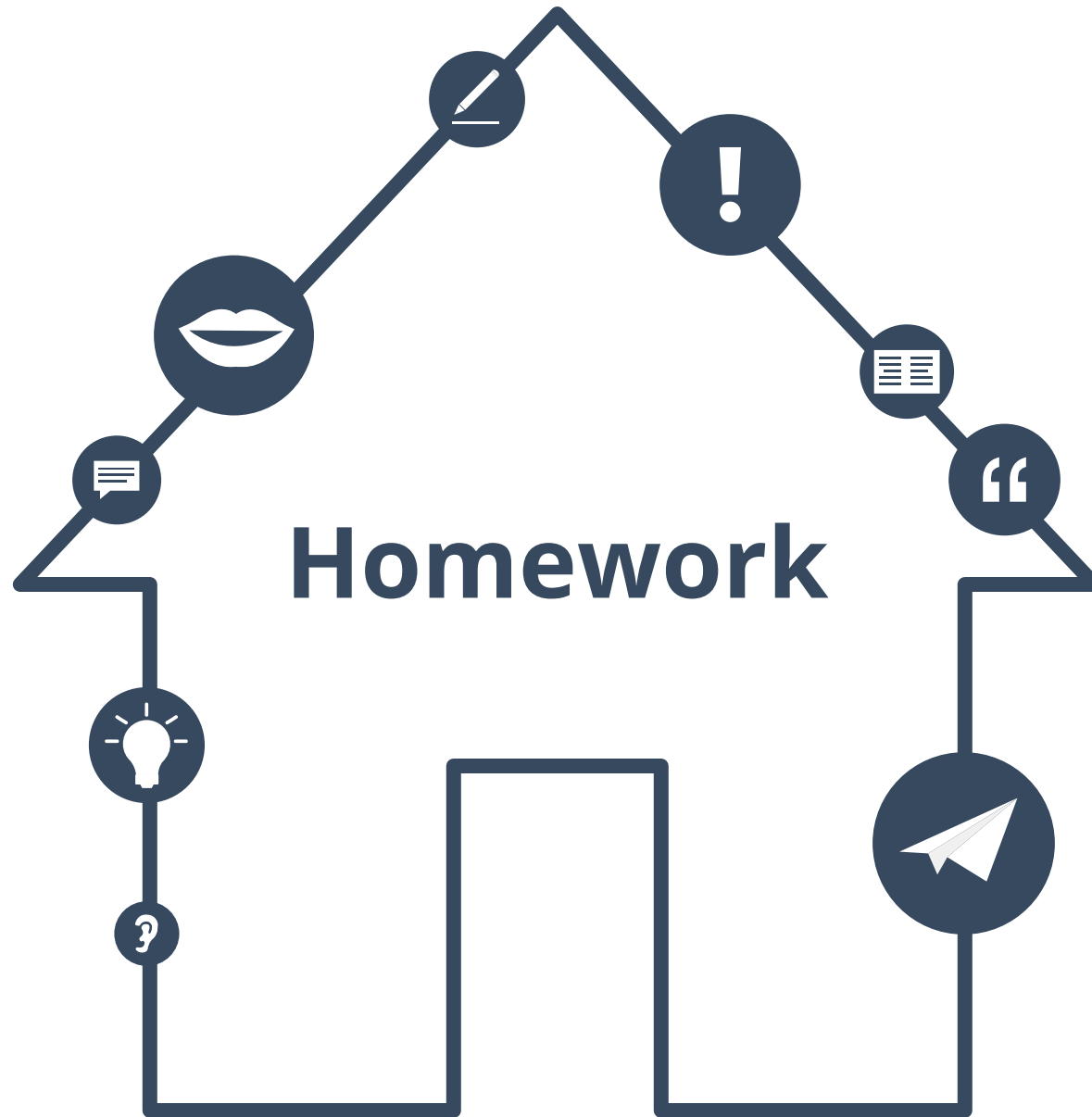
Rosie thinks she **could have left** it in the staff room but she **might not have** brought it to work today at all. Someone **must have used** it by mistake. What does it look like? It is a lovely deep red with cool white snowflakes on it. Whoever took it **must have noticed** them. It is a very recognisable and desirable mug. Well Philippe says it **can't have been** him who took it, as he hasn't had a hot drink today. Rosie says she took it out of the cupboard and then her phone rang, so she went to her desk. It **must have been taken** then. I don't think we should waste time on this...

Exercise p. 18

2. Someone **could have been listening**.
3. I **can't have been snoring** that loudly.
4. Joanna **might have been watching** before she went to bed.

Exercise p. 19

1. e 2. g 3. b 4. h 5. f 6. a
7. c or d – possible answer: The driver **must have been speeding**.
8. c or d – possible answer: They **could have been baking** together.





Homework writing activity

Imagine that you don't know what your best friend or partner did last night. What might they have been doing? Use past modals of deduction like the examples below.

He couldn't have been very busy because he rang me twice.

He might have gone to the pub to watch the football.

He could've been babysitting my friend's child.

She mustn't have gone out because she starts work early today.

He may not have done anything at all.

He didn't have plans so he can't have had much fun.

☐ My best friend couldn't have been at
☐ home last night because he has a
☐ concert tonight and needed to
☐ prepare, but he might have gone out to
☐ visit his girlfriend.
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